POU33201: Authoritarianism

Module outline — Michaelmas Term 2026

15 October 2026

Term	Michaelmas Term 2026
Credits	5 ECTS
Lecturer	Dr Noah Buckley — noah.buckley@tcd.ie
Teaching assistant	Michaela Nudo
Office hours	By appointment
Lectures	**Fridays 14:00–16:00**, 18 Sep – 4 Dec · Arts Building 2041B
Course website	noahbuckley.me/teaching/pou33201-mt2026
Assessment	Response papers 10% · mid-term essay 30% · examination 60%

Module description

Why do some rulers govern without meaningful elections, free media, or the rule of law — and why are so many of them so durable? This module introduces the comparative politics of authoritarian regimes: how dictatorships are organised, how they survive, and how they fall.

We examine the major varieties of authoritarian rule — personalist, single-party, military, monarchical, and hybrid or "electoral authoritarian" — and the core strategies autocrats use to stay in power: co-optation, repression, propaganda, elections without democracy, and managing rival elites. Cases are drawn from Russia, China, the Middle East, Latin America, and Africa.

The organising idea runs through every week: a dictator has two problems, not one — controlling the people who put him in power, and controlling everybody else. Nearly everything authoritarian regimes do (parties, parliaments, elections, propaganda, the secret police) is an answer to one of those two problems, and by the end of term you should be able to look at an unfamiliar regime and work out which one it is currently losing.

Learning outcomes

On successful completion of this module, you should be able to:

- Distinguish between the major types of authoritarian regime and explain how they differ in their institutions and survival strategies.
- Explain the central dilemmas autocrats face — the problems of power-sharing and of control — and the tools they use to manage them.
- Evaluate competing theories of authoritarian durability, repression, co-optation, and regime

breakdown.
- Assess how elections, parties, propaganda, and information operate under authoritarian conditions.
- Apply concepts and research from comparative politics to analyse contemporary authoritarian regimes and the global state of democracy.

How the module works

Lectures

There are **eleven lectures**, one a week, **Fridays 14:00–16:00**, across teaching weeks 1–6 and 8–12. Reading week (teaching week 7) has no lecture.

Discussion happens inside the two-hour block: each session mixes presentation with argument, cases, and questions. Come having done the reading.

Attendance is not taken, but material is covered in the room that is not in the readings, and the slides are a prompt for what I say, not a transcript of it.

Slides are posted on the course website after each lecture.

Readings

There is **no set textbook**. Readings are journal articles and book chapters. Journal articles you find yourself, through the Library or Google Scholar — part of the training. Book chapters and anything else you cannot easily find are provided via Blackboard. Five books recur often enough that you will get to know them:

- Milan Svolik, *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule* (Cambridge, 2012)
- Barbara Geddes, Joseph Wright & Erica Frantz, *How Dictatorships Work* (Cambridge, 2018)
- Steven Levitsky & Lucan Way, *Competitive Authoritarianism* (Cambridge, 2010)
- Jennifer Gandhi, *Political Institutions under Dictatorship* (Cambridge, 2008)
- Sergei Guriev & Daniel Treisman, *Spin Dictators* (Princeton, 2022)

Each week has required readings to complete before the lecture, plus recommended readings for going deeper. Some weeks also carry a short **Bonus** list — a blog post, an essay, a podcast episode, a film. Bonus items are not course material: not required, not examinable, and not sources for your written work. The list in the schedule below is indicative; Blackboard and the course website carry the current version.

Assessment

Component	Weight
Response papers	10%
Mid-term essay	30%
End-of-term examination (in person)	60%

Full instructions, prompts and essay questions are released in lecture and on Blackboard.

Response papers (10%)

Short pieces of **thinking**, not summary: take the week's required readings and *do something* with them — challenge an argument, apply it to a case the author didn't use, put two readings into conflict, or connect the reading to something happening now.

- **Length:** 500–700 words, +/- 10%.
- **How many:** two across the term — one in teaching weeks 1–6, one in teaching weeks 8–12. You choose the weeks.
- **Due:** Wednesday 23:59 in the week you choose, via Blackboard.
- **Marking:** each paper receives a mark; the two together make up the 10%.
- **The test:** could someone who has already done the reading learn something from your response? Restating the argument fails that test; arguing with it passes.

Full instructions: the response paper sheet.

Mid-term essay (30%)

An analytical essay of **2,000 words**, 10% either way (excluding bibliography), answering one of several set questions, building an argument out of the academic literature rather than summarising it. Questions are released in lecture and on Blackboard in due course.

- **Due:** Sunday 1 November 2026, 23:59.
- **Submission:** Word or PDF via Blackboard, which submits to Turnitin.

Examination (60%)

An **in-person examination** at the end of term, covering the whole module. It rewards the same thing the response papers do: applying a concept from the literature to a case, in your own words, under pressure.

The date is set centrally — check the College examination timetable. Format details will be given later in term.

Written work: formatting requirements

In line with department guidelines, written work for this module must:

- observe the stated word limit and state the final word count — **limits carry a 10% tolerance either way, and going outside that range costs up to 5 marks**;
- be submitted to Blackboard, in Word or PDF format;
- use proper citation and referencing — any consistent style is acceptable (the TCD Library style guide will help);

- include an alphabetised bibliography;
- be spellchecked;
- have the School of Social Sciences and Philosophy Assignment Submission Form attached as its first page, completed in full (see *Academic integrity* below).

Back your work up, and submit early enough to survive a technical problem. Keep your submission receipt. Computer crashes, corrupted files, and internet problems are not grounds for late submission.

Policies

Late work

All late work, unless excused in advance by me, is penalised at **5 marks per day or part thereof, up to a maximum of 20 marks**. There are many good reasons a student cannot submit on time and I am happy to make reasonable accommodations, but not for requests made after the deadline or a few hours before it.

Requests go through your **College Tutor**, who contacts me. Extensions are not granted retrospectively except in exceptional medical circumstances, which require a medical certificate. Work is not accepted after it has been marked and returned to other students, or after the end of teaching term — in both cases the mark is 0. It is your responsibility to make sure your College Tutor knows the correct procedure.

Contacting me

Email me at noah.buckley@tcd.ie. Read this document first.

I will do my best to reply within **two business days**. Email is for logistics: extensions, difficulties, things only I can settle. For substantive questions about the material, come to office hours (by appointment) or raise it in lecture. I will not be able to fill you in on a lecture you missed.

Disability

Students with a disability liable to affect their ability to participate fully in this — or any — module are encouraged to register with the University's Disability Service, which exists to make sure appropriate accommodations are in place.

Discussion in the room

The lecture is where the arguing happens. People in the room have different backgrounds and personal stakes in these questions — several of the regimes we study are somebody's home country. Engage seriously with the arguments and generously with the people making them.

Keeping up with current events

Read the news! Any serious source you like, national or international. This is a module about the present tense as much as the past one. Half the value of it is having something concrete in your head when a concept turns up, and the other half is noticing that a concept explains something you read last week.

Academic integrity

Do not plagiarise. Academic dishonesty is a serious matter with serious consequences, up to and including no credit for the assignment, failure of the module, and expulsion. It is never permissible to submit work containing other people's ideas without acknowledgment, and careless note-taking is not an excuse: put direct quotations in quotation marks, and reference paraphrases too. Trinity's guidance is at libguides.tcd.ie/plagiarism, and if you have not already completed the Library's Ready, Steady, Write tutorial, do that before your first submission. You must also submit only *new* work — not work submitted previously for another module.

Generative AI

These tools exist, you probably use them, and you will almost certainly use them in whatever you do after you get your college degree. But this module is not assessing whether you can obtain a competent paragraph about authoritarian politics from an LLM. It is assessing whether *you* can read an argument, find its weak point, and put your own case in your own words. So, in general: **use these tools to help guide you and to help you fix your prose; do not use them to do your thinking or produce the prose.**

What is permitted for each assessment is in that assessment's sheet, in the vocabulary of the School of Social Sciences and Philosophy Assignment Submission Form — the same words you tick on the form. "Permitted" means you may do it and must tick the box. "Not permitted" means doing it is an academic integrity matter, whether or not you disclose it. The examination is in person and is not covered: nothing to declare, no form.

Trinity offers further resources in the Statement on Generative AI, the Library's GenAI guide, and the College GenAI hub.

The Assignment Submission Form

Every piece of written work — response papers and the mid-term essay — must have the Assignment Submission Form as its first page. This is a department-wide rule. The form is on Blackboard in Word and PDF. Complete it in full, including the plagiarism declaration and the GenAI disclosure, ticking every category that applies to what you actually did. **A submission without a completed form is not accepted** — it is returned unmarked and treated as not submitted, accruing late penalties until you resubmit with one. The form does not count toward your word limit, and ticking a permitted box carries no penalty.

I reserve the right to modify this outline as necessary during term. The current version is always the one on the course website and Blackboard.

Schedule

Part I — Foundations

Teaching week 1 · Fri 18 September

What is authoritarianism? How much of the world is unfree, and the two questions the module returns to: how autocracies work, and why they last.

Required:

- Erica Frantz. 2018. *Authoritarianism: What Everyone Needs to Know*. Oxford University Press. pp. 1–13.
- Sergei Guriev and Daniel Treisman. 2019. "Informational Autocrats." *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 33(4): 100–127.

Recommended:

- Juan J. Linz. 2000. *Totalitarian and Authoritarian Regimes*. Lynne Rienner Publishers. Ch. 1.
- Barbara Geddes, Joseph Wright and Erica Frantz. 2018. *How Dictatorships Work*. Cambridge University Press.
- Robert A. Dahl. 1971. *Polyarchy: Participation and Opposition*. Yale University Press.
- Juan J. Linz and Alfred Stepan. 1996. *Problems of Democratic Transition and Consolidation: Southern Europe, South America, and Post-Communist Europe*. Johns Hopkins University Press. Ch. 3.

Teaching week 2 · Fri 25 September

Varieties of autocracy. Personalist, single-party, military, monarchical and hybrid regimes, and why classifying them is hard.

Required:

- Erica Frantz. 2018. *Authoritarianism: What Everyone Needs to Know*. Oxford University Press. Ch. 5.
- Steven Levitsky and Lucan A. Way. 2002. "Elections Without Democracy: The Rise of Competitive Authoritarianism." *Journal of Democracy* 13(2): 51–65.
- Milan W. Svolik. 2012. *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*. Cambridge University Press. Ch. 1 and 2 (pp. 1–45). **This is dense and sometimes technical – focus on the main ideas**

Recommended:

- Jason Brownlee. 2007. "Hereditary Succession in Modern Autocracies." *World Politics* 59(4): 595–628.
- Beatriz Magaloni and Ruth Kricheli. 2010. "Political Order and One-Party Rule." *Annual Review of Political Science* 13: 123–143.
- Larry Diamond. 2002. "Elections Without Democracy: Thinking About Hybrid Regimes." *Journal of Democracy* 13(2): 21–35.
- Juan J. Linz. 2000. *Totalitarian and Authoritarian Regimes*. Lynne Rienner Publishers. Ch. 2.
- David Collier and Steven Levitsky. 1997. "Democracy with Adjectives: Conceptual Innovation

in Comparative Research." *World Politics* 49(3): 430–451.
- Victor Menaldo. 2012. "The Middle East and North Africa's Resilient Monarchs." *The Journal of Politics* 74(3): 707–722.
- H. E. Chehabi and Juan J. Linz. 1998. *Sultanistic Regimes*. Johns Hopkins University Press. Ch. 1.

Part II — The dictator's dilemmas

Teaching week 3 · Fri 2 October

How autocrats take and hold power. Ruling coalitions, elites, and why autocrats can't simply trust one another.

Required:

- Barbara Geddes, Joseph Wright and Erica Frantz. 2018. *How Dictatorships Work*. Cambridge University Press. Chs. 1–2.
- Milan W. Svolik. 2012. *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*. Cambridge University Press. Ch. 3 (pp. 53–63).

Recommended:

- Daron Acemoglu and James Robinson. 2006. *Economic Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy*. Cambridge University Press. Introduction.
- Georgy Egorov and Konstantin Sonin. 2011. "Dictators and Their Viziers: Endogenizing the Loyalty-Competence Trade-off." *Journal of the European Economic Association* 9(5): 903–930.
- Carles Boix and Milan W. Svolik. 2013. "The Foundations of Limited Authoritarian Government: Institutions, Commitment, and Power-Sharing in Dictatorships." *Journal of Politics* 75(2): 300–316.
- Gordon Tullock. 1987. *Autocracy*. Kluwer Academic Publishers.
- Bruce Bueno de Mesquita and Alastair Smith. 2011. *The Dictator's Handbook: Why Bad Behavior Is Almost Always Good Politics*. 1 ed. PublicAffairs.
- Roger B. Myerson. 2008. "The Autocrat's Credibility Problem and Foundations of the Constitutional State." *American Political Science Review* 102(1): 125–139.

Teaching week 4 · Fri 9 October

The control problem: repression. Too much repression and too little are both dangerous — does it work, and when does it backfire?

Required:

- Christian Davenport. 2007. "State Repression and Political Order." *Annual Review of Political Science* 10(1): 1–23.
- Ronald Wintrobe. 1998. *The Political Economy of Dictatorship*. Cambridge University Press. Selected pages TBA.
- Milan W. Svolik. 2012. *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*. Cambridge University Press. Ch. 5 (pp. 123–138).

Recommended:

- Gary King, Jennifer Pan and Margaret E. Roberts. 2013. "How Censorship in China Allows Government Criticism but Silences Collective Expression." *American Political Science Review* 107(2): 326–343.
- Lisa Blaydes. 2018. *State of Repression: Iraq under Saddam Hussein*. Princeton University Press. Ch. 1.
- Ronald Wintrobe. 1990. "The Tinpot and the Totalitarian: An Economic Theory of Dictatorship." *American Political Science Review* 84(3): 849–872.
- Mai Hassan, Daniel Mattingly and Elizabeth R. Nugent. 2022. "Political Control." *Annual Review of Political Science* 25: 155–174.

Part III — Survival strategies

Teaching week 5 · Fri 16 October

Buying loyalty: parties, parliaments & patronage. Why dictatorships bother with parties and parliaments, and who's worth buying — elites or masses.

Required:

- Jennifer Gandhi and Adam Przeworski. 2007. "Authoritarian Institutions and the Survival of Autocrats." *Comparative Political Studies* 40(11): 1279–1301.
- Beatriz Magaloni. 2008. "Credible Power-Sharing and the Longevity of Authoritarian Rule." *Comparative Political Studies* 41(4–5): 715–741.

Recommended:

- Ellen Lust-Okar. 2006. "Elections Under Authoritarianism: Preliminary Lessons From Jordan." *Demokratizatsiya: The Journal of Post-Soviet Democratization* 13(3): 1–17.
- Milan W. Svolik. 2012. *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*. Cambridge University Press. Ch. 6.
- Lisa Blaydes. 2011. *Elections and Distributive Politics in Mubarak's Egypt*. Cambridge University Press.
- Adam Przeworski and Fernando Limongi. 1993. "Political Regimes and Economic Growth." *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 7(3): 51–69.
- Mancur Olson. 1993. "Dictatorship, Democracy, and Development." *American Political Science Review* 87(3): 567–576.
- Jennifer Gandhi. 2008. *Political Institutions Under Dictatorship*. Cambridge University Press.
- Thomas B. Pepinsky. 2014. "The Institutional Turn in Comparative Authoritarianism." *British Journal of Political Science* 44(3): 631–653.
- Ora John Reuter. 2017. *The Origins of Dominant Parties: Building Authoritarian Institutions in Post-Soviet Russia*. Cambridge University Press.

Teaching week 6 · Fri 23 October

Elections without democracy. Why hold elections you might lose or have to rig, and what elections actually do for autocrats.

Required:

- Andreas Schedler. 2002. "Elections Without Democracy: The Menu of Manipulation." *Journal of Democracy* 13(2): 36–50.
- Beatriz Magaloni. 2006. *Voting for Autocracy*. Cambridge University Press. Introduction (pp. 1–43).

Recommended:

- Carl Henrik Knutsen, Håvard Mokleiv Nygård and Tore Wig. 2017. "Autocratic Elections: Stabilizing Tool or Force for Change?" *World Politics* 69(1): 98–143.
- Alberto Simpser. 2013. *Why Governments and Parties Manipulate Elections*. Cambridge University Press. Selected chapter.
- Andrew T. Little. 2015. "Fraud and Monitoring in Non-Competitive Elections." *Political Science Research and Methods* 3(1): 21–41.
- Jennifer Gandhi and Ellen Lust-Okar. 2009. "Elections Under Authoritarianism." *Annual Review of Political Science* 12: 403–422.
- Andreas Schedler. 2013. *The Politics of Uncertainty: Sustaining and Subverting Electoral Authoritarianism*. Oxford University Press.

Reading week (teaching week 7) — w/c Monday 26 October. No lecture. Teaching resumes with teaching week 8 on Friday 6 November.

Teaching week 8 · Fri 6 November

Propaganda & censorship. Fear dictators against spin dictators, and why produce propaganda nobody believes.

Required:

- Sergei Guriev and Daniel Treisman. 2022. *Spin Dictators*. Princeton University Press. Chapters 3 and 4.
- Haifeng Huang. 2015. "Propaganda as Signaling." *Comparative Politics* 47(4): 419–444.

Recommended:

- Gary King, Jennifer Pan and Margaret E. Roberts. 2013. "How Censorship in China Allows Government Criticism but Silences Collective Expression." *American Political Science Review* 107(2): 326–343.
- Hannah Arendt. 1951. *The Origins of Totalitarianism*. Harcourt Brace Jovanovich. Selected pages, on propaganda.
- Václav Havel. 1985. "The Power of the Powerless." In *The Power of the Powerless: Citizens Against the State in Central-Eastern Europe*, edited by John Keane. Routledge.
- Arturas Rozenas and Denis Stukal. 2019. "How Autocrats Manipulate Economic News: Evidence from Russia's State-Controlled Television." *The Journal of Politics* 81(3): 982–996.
- Georgy Egorov, Sergei Guriev and Konstantin Sonin. 2009. "Why Resource-Poor Dictators Allow Freer Media: A Theory and Evidence from Panel Data." *American Political Science*

Review 103(4): 645–668.

Teaching week 9 · Fri 13 November

Digital authoritarianism. What mass surveillance actually buys a regime, and how autocrats reach dissidents abroad.

Required:

- Sebastian Hellmeier. 2016. "The Dictator's Digital Toolkit: Explaining Variation in Internet Filtering in Authoritarian Regimes." *Politics & Policy* 44(6): 1158–1191.
- Xu Xu. 2021. "To Repress or to Co-opt? Authoritarian Control in the Age of Digital Surveillance." *American Journal of Political Science* 65(2): 309–325.

Recommended:

- Freedom House. *Freedom on the Net* (latest edition). https://freedomhouse.org/report/freedom-net.
- Margaret E. Roberts. 2018. *Censored: Distraction and Diversion Inside China's Great Firewall*. Princeton University Press. Selected chapter.
- Eda Keremoğlu and Nils B. Weidmann. 2020. "How Dictators Control the Internet: A Review Essay." *Comparative Political Studies* 53(10–11): 1690–1703.
- Gary King, Jennifer Pan and Margaret E. Roberts. 2017. "How the Chinese Government Fabricates Social Media Posts for Strategic Distraction, Not Engaged Argument." *American Political Science Review* 111(3): 484–501.
- Steven Feldstein. 2021. *The Rise of Digital Repression: How Technology Is Reshaping Power, Politics, and Resistance*. Oxford University Press.

Part IV — Threats & breakdown

Teaching week 10 · Fri 20 November

How autocracies end: coups, succession & revolution. Threats from the palace and from the street, why the army decides which one wins, and the most dangerous moment of all: handing over power.

Required:

- Timur Kuran. 1991. "Now Out of Never: The Element of Surprise in the East European Revolution of 1989." *World Politics* 44(1): 7–48.
- Barbara Geddes, Joseph Wright and Erica Frantz. 2014. "Autocratic Breakdown and Regime Transitions: A New Data Set." *Perspectives on Politics* 12(2): 313–331.
- Sheena Chestnut Greitens. 2016. *Dictators and Their Secret Police: Coercive Institutions and State Violence*. Cambridge University Press. Ch. 1.

Recommended:

- James T. Quinlivan. 1999. "Coup-Proofing: Its Practice and Consequences in the Middle East." *International Security* 24(2): 131–165.
- Barbara Geddes, Joseph Wright and Erica Frantz. 2018. *How Dictatorships Work*. Cambridge University Press. Chapter 3.
- Zoltan Barany. 2011. "The Role of the Military." *Journal of Democracy* 22(4): 24–35.

- Erica De Bruin. 2020. *How to Prevent Coups d'État: Counterbalancing and Regime Survival*. Cornell University Press.
- Philip Roessler. 2011. "The Enemy Within: Personal Rule, Coups, and Civil War in Africa." *World Politics* 63(2): 300–346.
- Samuel P. Huntington. 1968. *Political Order in Changing Societies*. Yale University Press.
- Joshua A. Tucker. 2007. "Enough! Electoral Fraud, Collective Action Problems, and Post-Communist Colored Revolutions." *Perspectives on Politics* 5(3): 535–551.
- Susanne Lohmann. 1994. "The Dynamics of Informational Cascades: The Monday Demonstrations in Leipzig, East Germany, 1989–91." *World Politics* 47(1): 42–101.
- Steven Levitsky and Lucan A. Way. 2022. *Revolution and Dictatorship: The Violent Origins of Durable Authoritarianism*. Princeton University Press.

Part V — Backsliding & democratization

Teaching week 11 · Fri 27 November

How democracies erode: Hungary, Brazil & the United States. Autocracy at home? How elected leaders take a democracy apart from the inside, and what stops them.

Required:

- Nancy Bermeo. 2016. "On Democratic Backsliding." *Journal of Democracy* 27(1): 5–19.
- Steven Levitsky and Daniel Ziblatt. 2018. *How Democracies Die*. Crown. Selected chapters TBA.
- Anna Lührmann and Staffan I. Lindberg. 2019. "A Third Wave of Autocratization Is Here: What Is New About It?" *Democratization* 26(7): 1095–1113.

Recommended:

- David Waldner and Ellen Lust. 2018. "Unwelcome Change: Coming to Terms With Democratic Backsliding." *Annual Review of Political Science* 21(1): 93–113.
- Milan W. Svolik. 2019. "Polarization versus Democracy." *Journal of Democracy* 30(3): 20–32.
- Juan J. Linz. 1990. "The Perils of Presidentialism." *Journal of Democracy* 1(1): 51–69.
- V-Dem Institute. *Democracy Report* (latest edition). https://v-dem.net/.

Teaching week 12 · Fri 4 December

Democratization & the outside world. How autocracies become democracies, what other states can and can't do about it, and where the module leaves you.

Required:

- Daniel Treisman. 2020. "Democracy by Mistake: How the Errors of Autocrats Trigger Transitions to Freer Government." *American Political Science Review* 114(3): 792–810.
- Steven Levitsky and Lucan Way. 2010. *Competitive Authoritarianism: Hybrid Regimes After the Cold War*. Cambridge University Press. Ch. on linkage and leverage.

Recommended:

- Guillermo O'Donnell and Philippe C. Schmitter. 1986. *Transitions from Authoritarian Rule: Tentative Conclusions about Uncertain Democracies*. Johns Hopkins University Press. Ch. 4.

- Samuel P. Huntington. 1991. "Democracy's Third Wave." *Journal of Democracy* 2(2): 12–34.
- Seva Gunitsky. 2014. "From Shocks to Waves: Hegemonic Transitions and Democratization in the Twentieth Century." *International Organization* 68(3): 561–597.
- Abel Escribà-Folch and Joseph Wright. 2010. "Dealing With Tyranny: International Sanctions and the Survival of Authoritarian Rulers." *International Studies Quarterly* 54(2): 335–359.
- Paul Poast and Johannes Urpelainen. 2015. "How International Organizations Support Democratization: Preventing Authoritarian Reversals or Promoting Consolidation?" *World Politics* 67(1): 72–113.
- Lucan Way. 2015. *Pluralism by Default: Weak Autocrats and the Rise of Competitive Politics*. Johns Hopkins University Press. Selected chapter.

MT teaching ends **Friday 4 December 2026**. The examination is scheduled centrally — check the College examination timetable.